MENTAL HEALTH

# The Anxiety Recovery Journal

*A 90-day guided journal combining CBT, gratitude & cognitive reframing*

**Dr. Hala Ali**
Mama Hala Consulting

## A 90-Day Guided Journal Combining CBT, Gratitude & Cognitive Reframing

> 💡 *This journal won't cure your anxiety. But it will teach you to stop being afraid of it.*

Anxiety tells you a lot of lies. It tells you that the worst will happen. It tells you that you can't handle it. It tells you that worrying keeps you safe, and that if you stop worrying, something terrible will slip through.

This journal is designed to help you catch those lies — gently, without judgment — and replace them with something closer to the truth. Over the next 90 days, you'll learn to observe your anxious thoughts without believing every one of them, to understand the patterns that keep your anxiety alive, and to build new habits that shrink the space anxiety occupies in your life.

This is not about becoming fearless. It's about becoming brave enough to live fully, even when anxiety is along for the ride.

## How to Use This Journal

- **5 minutes in the morning.** Set your intention. Name what you're grateful for. Ground yourself before the day begins.
- **5 minutes in the evening.** Reflect on what happened. Record your thoughts. Notice what was real and what was anxiety talking.
- **Be honest, not perfect.** You don't need to write beautifully. You don't need to fill every line. You just need to show up.
- **Don't skip days — but forgive yourself when you do.** If you miss a day, pick up where you left off. The streak doesn't matter. The practice does.
- **Keep this private.** This journal is for your eyes only. That freedom is what makes it work.

# Section 1: Understanding Your Anxiety

## Days 1-7

*Before you can change your relationship with anxiety, you need to understand it. This first week is about mapping the territory — no fixing yet, just noticing.*

### Day 1: What Does Anxiety Feel Like in My Body?

Anxiety isn't just in your head. It lives in your body — your chest, your stomach, your jaw, your hands. Today, notice where you feel it.

**Morning Intention:** Today, I will pay attention to my body's signals.

**3 things I'm grateful for this morning:**

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

**Evening Reflection:**

When I felt anxious today, I noticed it in my body as:

- ☐ Racing heart
- ☐ Tight chest
- ☐ Shallow breathing
- ☐ Stomach knots or nausea

- [ ] Tension in shoulders/neck/jaw
- [ ] Restlessness or inability to sit still
- [ ] Tingling or numbness in hands
- [ ] Headache
- [ ] Fatigue
- [ ] Other: _____

**The part of my body that holds the most anxiety:**

_____

**If that body part could speak, it would say:**

_____

---

## Day 2: My Anxiety Timeline — When Did It Start?

Anxiety rarely appears from nowhere. It usually has a history. Today, trace yours.

**Morning Intention:** Today, I will be gentle with myself as I look back.

**3 things I'm grateful for this morning:**

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

**Evening Reflection:**

**My earliest memory of feeling anxious:**

_____

_____

**When my anxiety became a pattern (age, event, or period of life):**

_____

**Things that may have contributed (check all that apply):**

- [ ] A specific traumatic event
- [ ] Ongoing stress (school, work, family)
- [ ] A major life change or transition
- [ ] Growing up in an environment where worry was normal
- [ ] Health issues (mine or someone close to me)
- [ ] Loss or grief
- [ ] Not sure — it feels like it's always been there
- [ ] Other: _____

**What I want my younger self to know:**

_____

---

## Day 3: The Thoughts That Fuel My Worry

Anxiety is powered by thoughts — often the same ones, on repeat. Today, catch them.

**Morning Intention:** Today, I will notice my anxious thoughts without trying to fix them.

**3 things I'm grateful for this morning:**

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

**Evening Reflection:**

**The top 3 anxious thoughts that showed up today:**

1. _____
1. _____
1. _____

**The thought that played on repeat the most:**

_____

**Common thinking patterns I notice in myself:**

- ☐ Catastrophizing (jumping to the worst-case scenario)
- ☐ Mind reading (assuming I know what others are thinking)
- ☐ Fortune telling (predicting the future — always negatively)
- ☐ All-or-nothing thinking ("If it's not perfect, it's a disaster")
- ☐ Discounting the positive ("That doesn't count")
- ☐ Should statements ("I should be able to handle this")
- ☐ Personalization (blaming myself for things outside my control)
- ☐ Overgeneralization ("This always happens")

---

## Day 4: My Safety Behaviors — What I Avoid

Anxiety shrinks your world by convincing you to avoid things. Today, get honest about what you're avoiding.

**Morning Intention:** Today, I will notice what I avoid and why.

**3 things I'm grateful for this morning:**

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

**Evening Reflection:**

**Things I avoid because of anxiety:**

| What I avoid | What I'm afraid will happen | How likely is that, really? (0-100%) |
|---|---|---|
| | | % |
| | | % |
| | | % |
| | | % |
| | | % |

**The avoidance that costs me the most:**

_____

**What my life would look like if I didn't avoid this thing:**

_____

---

## Day 5: What Anxiety Has Cost Me

This isn't about self-pity. It's about getting clear on the stakes — the real reasons you're doing this work.

**Morning Intention:** Today, I will be honest about what anxiety has taken from me.

**3 things I'm grateful for this morning:**

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

**Evening Reflection:**

**Anxiety has cost me in these areas:**

- **Relationships:** _____
- **Career or school:** _____
- **Health:** _____
- **Joy and fun:** _____
- **Confidence:** _____
- **Experiences I missed:** _____

**The thing I most want to reclaim:**

_____

---

## Day 6: What I've Tried So Far

You've been coping — maybe not perfectly, but you've been trying. Give yourself credit, and also notice what hasn't worked.

**Morning Intention:** Today, I will acknowledge my own resilience.

**3 things I'm grateful for this morning:**

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

**Evening Reflection:**

**Things I've tried to manage my anxiety:**

| Strategy | Helpful? | Still using it? |
|---|---|---|
| _____ | Yes / Somewhat / No | Yes / No |
| _____ | Yes / Somewhat / No | Yes / No |
| _____ | Yes / Somewhat / No | Yes / No |
| _____ | Yes / Somewhat / No | Yes / No |
| _____ | Yes / Somewhat / No | Yes / No |

**My most effective coping tool right now:**

Something I've been doing that actually makes my anxiety worse:

### Day 7: Week 1 Reflection

**Morning Intention:** Today, I will reflect on what I've learned about myself this week.

3 things I'm grateful for this morning:

1. 
2. 
3. 

Evening Reflection:

The biggest thing I learned about my anxiety this week:

Something that surprised me:

My anxiety level this week (1 = barely there, 10 = overwhelming):

Mon: Tue: Wed: Thu: Fri: Sat: Sun:

One word to describe how I feel right now:

# Section 2: The CBT Toolkit

## Days 8-30

*Now that you understand your anxiety, it's time to start working with it. Cognitive Behavioral Therapy (CBT) is one of the most researched and effective approaches to anxiety. The core idea is simple: your thoughts shape your feelings, and your feelings shape your behavior. Change the thought, and the rest begins to shift.*

*For the next 23 days, you'll follow a daily structure of morning intention-setting and evening thought recording.*

## Daily Structure (Days 8-30)

### Morning Page

Date:

Today's intention (one sentence about how I want to show up today):

3 things I'm grateful for:

1. 
2. 

3 _____

My anxiety level right now (1-10): _____

One thing I'm looking forward to today:

_____

## Evening Thought Record

The situation that triggered anxiety today:

_____

The automatic thought (what my mind told me):

_____

The emotion I felt (and intensity, 0-100%):

_____

Evidence that supports this thought:

_____

Evidence against this thought:

_____

A more balanced, realistic thought:

_____

How I feel after reframing (emotion and intensity, 0-100%):

_____

*Repeat this daily structure for Days 8 through 30. Use additional paper or a notebook if needed.*

## Weekly Pattern Recognition (Complete at the end of each week)

Week of: _____

My most common automatic thought this week:

_____

The thinking trap I fell into most:

_____

The reframe that helped the most:

_____

My average anxiety level this week (1-10): _____

Compared to last week: [ ] Higher [ ] Same [ ] Lower

One thing I'm doing differently because of this practice:

_____

# Section 3: Building New Patterns

## Days 31-60

*Understanding your thoughts is important. But anxiety also lives in your behavior — in what you avoid, what you flee from, what you never let yourself try. This section is about action: gradually, gently expanding what you're willing to do.*

### The Exposure Ladder

**How it works:** Choose something you avoid because of anxiety. Break it down into small steps, from least scary to most scary. Then work your way up, one step at a time.

**The thing I avoid:** _____

**Why I avoid it:** _____

| Step | Anxiety Level Before (1-10) | I Did It (Date) | Anxiety Level After (1-10) |
|---|---|---|---|
| 1. (Easiest) | | | |
| 2. | | | |
| 3. | | | |
| 4. | | | |
| 5. | | | |
| 6. | | | |
| 7. (Hardest) | | | |

### "What Happened vs. What I Predicted" Log

*Anxiety is a terrible fortune teller. This exercise builds evidence that your predictions are usually wrong.*

**Use this format daily or whenever you face something anxiety-provoking:**

| Date | What I was afraid would happen | What actually happened | What I learned |
|---|---|---|---|
| | | | |
| | | | |
| | | | |
| | | | |
| | | | |
| | | | |
| | | | |
| | | | |

**After 2 weeks of tracking, my prediction accuracy is about:** _____ %

**What this tells me about my anxious predictions:**

## Comfort Zone Expansion Tracker

**How it works:** Each week, choose one thing slightly outside your comfort zone. Record what happened.

| Week | What I tried | How it went | Would I do it again? |
|---|---|---|---|
| Week 5 | | | Yes / Maybe / No |
| Week 6 | | | Yes / Maybe / No |
| Week 7 | | | Yes / Maybe / No |
| Week 8 | | | Yes / Maybe / No |

**The expansion I'm most proud of:**

## Values-Based Action Planning

*Anxiety makes you live reactively — avoiding what scares you. Values-based living means moving toward what matters to you, even when it's uncomfortable.*

**My top 5 values:**

1. 
2. 
3. 
4. 
5. 

**For each value, one action I can take this month — even if anxiety shows up:**

| Value | Action | Anxiety says I can't because... | I'll do it anyway because... |
|---|---|---|---|
| | | | |
| | | | |
| | | | |
| | | | |
| | | | |

*Continue the morning/evening journaling structure from Section 2 throughout Days 31-60. The morning page and evening thought record remain your daily anchor.*

# Section 4: Integration & Growth

## Days 61-90

*By now, you've built awareness, practiced reframing, and started taking action despite your anxiety. This final phase is about integration — weaving these skills into the fabric of your daily life so they stick.*

---

### Monthly Review: End of Month 1 (around Day 30)

My anxiety level at the start of this journal (1-10): _____

My anxiety level now (1-10): _____

The most useful tool I've learned so far:

_____

The hardest part of this process:

_____

Something I can do now that I couldn't do 30 days ago:

_____

---

### Monthly Review: End of Month 2 (around Day 60)

My anxiety level now (1-10): _____

Patterns I've broken or changed:

_____

Patterns that are still sticky:

_____

What I want to focus on in the final 30 days:

_____

---

### The Letter to My Anxiety

*Write a letter to your anxiety. Not to destroy it — to put it in its proper place.*

Dear Anxiety,

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

### The Letter from My Future Self

*Imagine yourself one year from now — calmer, braver, living more freely. What does that version of you want to say to the person writing in this journal today?*

Dear Present Me,

### Day 90: Celebration & Continuation Plan

**My anxiety level at the start of this journal (1-10):** _____

**My anxiety level today (1-10):** _____

**What has changed in 90 days:**

_____

_____

**What I'm most proud of:**

_____

**What's still hard:**

_____

**My plan for continuing this work:**

- ☐ I will keep a daily thought record
- ☐ I will continue my morning gratitude practice
- ☐ I will keep expanding my comfort zone weekly
- ☐ I will revisit my exposure ladder for new challenges
- ☐ I will seek professional support for: _____
- ☐ Other: _____

**My mantra going forward:**

_____

## Template Pages

*Photocopy or reprint these pages as needed throughout your 90 days.*

## Blank Thought Record

Date: _____

| | |
|---|---|
| Situation: | |
| Automatic thought: | |
| Emotion (0-100%): | |
| Evidence FOR the thought: | |
| Evidence AGAINST the thought: | |
| Balanced thought: | |
| New emotion (0-100%): | |

## Blank Exposure Ladder

Target behavior: _____

| Step | Description | Anxiety Before (1-10) | Date Completed | Anxiety After (1-10) |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1 (Easiest) | | | | |
| 2 | | | | |
| 3 | | | | |
| 4 | | | | |
| 5 | | | | |
| 6 | | | | |
| 7 (Hardest) | | | | |

## Daily Journal Page

### Morning (5 minutes)

Date: _____

Today's intention:

_____

3 gratitudes:

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

Anxiety level (1-10): _____

### Evening (5 minutes)

**The best part of today:**

_____

**The hardest part of today:**

_____

**One anxious thought I caught and reframed:**

- The thought: _____
- The reframe: _____

**Anxiety level (1-10):** _____

**Tomorrow, I want to:**

_____

## A Final Word

Ninety days ago, you started this journal. Maybe you were skeptical. Maybe you were desperate. Maybe you were just tired of anxiety running the show.

Whatever brought you here, you showed up. Day after day, you did the work of looking at your thoughts honestly, questioning what you'd always assumed was true, and taking small brave steps even when everything in you wanted to retreat.

Anxiety may still visit you. It probably will. But you are no longer the same person who opened this journal on Day 1. You have tools now. You have evidence that your worst fears usually don't come true. You have proof that you can feel afraid and do it anyway.

That's not the end of anxiety. It's the beginning of freedom.

**If your anxiety needs more support than a journal can provide**, that's not a failure — it's wisdom. Mama Hala Consulting offers individual counseling for anxiety, stress, and overwhelm, with sessions available in English and Arabic, in Ottawa, Dubai, and online.

**Book a consultation:** mamahala.ca **Email:** info@mamahala.ca

*You've done 90 days of hard, honest work. Whatever comes next, you are ready.*

# Ready for Personalized Support?

Your first conversation is free — 30 minutes, no pressure. Let's explore how counseling can help you and your family thrive.

Book Your Free Consultation

mamahala.ca • admin@mamahala.ca

Ottawa, Canada • Dubai, UAE

Bilingual services in English & Arabic

SCAN TO BOOK A SESSION

© 2026 Mama Hala Consulting. For personal use only. Do not reproduce or distribute without permission.